The Art Market Trap



The prices may be dazzling, but turning a canvas into cash is another story altogether.

BY KISHORE SINGH

Every concluded auction these days is accompanied by the chorus: "Did you see the prices? Aren't they insane?" Inevitably echoed by the refrain, "Can you tell us who to invest in?" And this is the conundrum that defines the 'art as investment' debate because even as art prices continue to soar and sing, art remains an illiquid asset that is showering dealers with riches but is on shakier ground for you and me. Who do I take an inherited M.F. Husain to for selling? Who will provide me with a fair valuation? Who can I sell it to, preferably discreetly? How do I find an interested buyer? What's the cut a dealer takes? Or a gallery? Will I have to wait months for an auction house to put it up for sale, and then some before I get the monies following the commissions charged from buyers and, in some cases, also sellers, thereby whittling down the sum considerably?

It's true that there are more questions than answers for those outside the charmed circle of the art world. It's a naïve idea if